

The Jerusalem Tophet Ideological Dispute and Religious Transformation

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Abstract

In the Hebrew Bible, the tophet is named as the site at which children are “passed over” or “burned” in fire to the god Molek. An absence of archaeological evidence for this site in Jerusalem renders scholars dependent on the biblical portrayal of this practice. However, this has led to clumsy caricatures of the tophet in modern scholarship. This article examines the biblical portrayal of the tophet afresh and argues that its sacred status as a powerful cult site associated with Yahweh, rather than Molek, permeates the biblical traditions.

Keywords

Tophet, sacrifice, infanticide, cremation, Molek, Yahweh, Ben Hinnom.

Given the increasing interest in child sacrifice in recent scholarly discussions of ancient Israelite and Judahite religions¹, nuanced debates specifically about the tophet – the site at which these rituals are assumed to have taken place – remain relatively scarce². Instead, the imagined nature and function of the tophet tends to be flattened out by commentators into abbreviated and clumsy caricatures that replicate uncritically the polemics of the biblical portrait³.

This tendency is facilitated by the relatively limited scope of this biblical portrayal. Indeed, despite numerous references and allusions to the sacrifice of children throughout the Hebrew Bible⁴, the tophet is mentioned in only a handful of texts (2 Kgs 23:10; Jer. 7:30-31; 19:6, 11-14)⁵. In the best known of these, it is portrayed as one among a number of “deviant” cult places dramatically destroyed in the seventh century BCE by the great hero of the biblical writers, King Josiah of Judah:

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¹ See, for example, BOEHM 2004; KESSLER 2004; STAVRAKOPOULOU 2004; FINSTERBUSCH – LANGE – DIETHARD RÖMHELD 2007; NOORT 2007; CHILTON 2008; BAUKS 2009.

² Of the few discussions there are, see especially DEARMAN 1996; BARRICK 2002; MULDER 2006; cf. SCHILLER 2011.

³ See particularly DAY 1989; SCHMITZ 1992.

⁴ For example, Gen. 22:1-19; Lev. 18:21; 20:2-5; Deut. 12:31; 18:10; Josh. 6:26; Judg. 11:30-40; 1 Kgs 16:34; 2 Kgs 3:27; 16:3; 17:17, 31; 21:6; 23:10; 2 Chr. 28:3; 33:6; Ps. 106:37-38; Isa. 57:5; Jer. 7:31; 19:5; 32:35; Ezek. 16:20-21; 20:26, 31; 23:37, 39; Mic. 6:7.

⁵ An apparent variant of the biblical term *tōpheth* also occurs as *tophteh* in Isa. 30:33, as discussed in section 2, below.

“The king commanded the high priest Hilkiah, the priests of the second order, and the guardians of the threshold, to bring out of the temple of Yahweh all the vessels made for Baal, for Asherah, and for all the Host of Heaven; he burned them outside Jerusalem in the fields of the Kidron and carried their ashes to Bethel. He deposed the idolatrous priests whom the kings of Judah had ordained to make offerings in the high places at the cities of Judah and around Jerusalem; those also who made offerings to Baal, to the sun, the moon, the constellations and to all the host of the heavens ... He defiled the tophet, which is in the Valley of Ben Hinnom, so that no one would make a son or a daughter pass over in the fire to Molek.” (2 Kgs 23:4-5, 10).

Supposedly prompted by the discovery of the lost scroll of Torah (2 Kgs 22:3-13), Josiah is said to have purged the land of all forms of idolatrous worship – including the veneration of “foreign” deities and their cult places – in order to abide by Mosaic law in “restoring” the religion of the state to the supposedly exclusive monotheism of Yahweh-worship (23:1-25). On the basis of this narrative concerning Josiah’s reform (and in spite of the acknowledged tendentiousness of the tradition itself, as well as a wealth of evidence attesting to the normatively polytheistic and diverse nature of Judahite religion)⁶, most commentators suppose that, historically, the tophet, its rituals and its recipient deity, Molek, were features of Judahite religion that were borrowed or imported from other cultures. The Molek cult, they argue, was a “Canaanite” or similarly “foreign” form of ritualised child sacrifice, alien to Yahweh and customary religious practice, and appropriately destroyed by the great reformer Josiah (2 Kgs 23:10)⁷.

At first blush, this understanding of the tophet might appear to be supported by the remainder of biblical references where it is identified as a cult place seemingly removed from Yahweh’s temple in Jerusalem, and the site at which sons and/or daughters are “burned” in fire in honour of a deity distinct from Yahweh. For example:

“... the people of Judah have done evil in my sight, says Yahweh ... they go on building the high place of tophet, which is in the Valley of Ben Hinnom, to burn their sons and daughters in the fire – which I did not command, nor did it come into my mind.” (Jer. 7:30-31; cf. 19:6, 11-14; cf. 32:35).

Further support for the “foreignness” of the tophet is drawn from additional references elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible to the “burning” (*šāraph*) or “passing over” (*ha’ābîr*) of children. Although the tophet goes unmentioned in these verses, some texts nonetheless associate the “passing over” or “burning” of children with the Molek cult (Lev. 18:21; 20:2-5), whilst others present these practices as cult crimes abhorrent to Yahweh, performed either by foreign nations (Deut. 12:29-31; 18:10; 2 Kgs 17:31) or by idolatrous, disobedient Yahweh-worshippers in honour of another – often unnamed – deity (2 Kgs 16:3; 21:6; 17:17; Ezek. 16:20-21; 20:31; 23:37-39).

Although there are notable ambiguities and discrepancies among all these texts, they tend to be treated as a coherent group and thus harmonised by biblical scholars with little attention to the specific nuances and strategies of individual passages.

⁶ On religious diversity, see STAVRAKOPOULOU – BARTON 2010. For debates about the historicity of Josiah’s reform, see the essays collected in GRABBE 2005.

⁷ E.g., HEIDER 1985; DAY 1989; MILLER 2000; BARRICK 2002; HESS 2007.

Collectively, these texts have therefore given rise to a pervasive caricature of the tophet in Western scholarship: it is marked out and othered as a deviant and foreign element within Judahite religion, a cult site devoted to an ancient “foreign” god long since abandoned in favour of the god of the Bible⁸. No surprise, then, that the Jerusalem tophet has also lent its name to those archaeological sites in North Africa and the eastern Mediterranean at which the burned remains of babies have been found buried in sacred precincts devoted to other long-abandoned ancient gods⁹.

But closer examination of the modern handling of these biblical texts suggests that this caricature persists because it serves the ideological (and perhaps theological) agenda of modern critics just as much as it did the biblical writers. Indeed, it is arguable that the majority of modern commentators have been so caught up with denying, limiting or apologising for the presence of child sacrifice in the biblical traditions that some of the powerful socio-religious and cultural contexts of the Jerusalem tophet itself have been overlooked.

1. Revisiting the Tophet

Whilst it has become a scholarly convention to designate Phoenician and Punic sites attesting to the cremation of children as “tophets”, the aligning of the biblical tophet with those archaeological sites risks mutual misinterpretation and distortion. Instead, each must be scrutinised on its own terms, and within its own cultural context, before constructive comparisons can be drawn. This exercise is further complicated by both the absence of archaeological evidence for a tophet in or around Jerusalem and the disputed reliability of the Hebrew Bible as an “historical” source.

Most scholarly discussions of the biblical tophet begin with an analysis of the meaning and etymology of the designation itself. In the Hebrew Bible, the term vocalised in the Masoretic text as *tōpheth* occurs only eight times: once in 2 Kgs 23:10, three times in Jer. 7:31-32, and four times in Jer. 19:6, 11-14. An apparent variant, Masoretic *tophteh*, also appears in Isa. 30:33¹⁰. In most of these texts, the term is used to designate a place associated with ritual fire or burning (explicitly so in 2 Kgs 23:10; Isa. 30:33; Jer. 7:31-32; implicitly in Jer. 19:6), although in Jer. 19:11-14, it appears to be employed more ambivalently as a toponym. Whilst some have suggested the standard Masoretic vocalisation of *tōpheth* is deliberately loaded, parroting the vowels of *bōsheth*, “shame”, or spoofing the derogatory use of *tōpheth*, “spit”, in Job 17:6¹¹, its relative infrequency in the Hebrew Bible prohibits any consensus regarding its etymology. Nonetheless, a number of scholars – relying on the fiery contexts in which the term is used – choose to render *tōpheth* as “firepit” on the assumption it is related to

⁸ See especially HEIDER 1985; DAY 1989.

⁹ These sites include those at Carthage and Sousse in North Africa, Motya in Sicily, plus those identified in Sardinia, Malta, and possibly Amathus in Cyprus. The scholarly literature on these excavations and their interpretation is vast, but note in particular STAGER 1980; STAGER 1982; BROWN 1991; BÉNICHOU-SAFAR 2004; BONNET 2011; QUINN 2011; XELLA 2012; VELLA 2013; plus the literature cited in the essays in the present collection.

¹⁰ The Versions render the term variously; see STAVRAKOPOULOU 2004: 152.

¹¹ E.g., DEARMAN 1996; NOORT 2007. This proposal is attractive to those adopting GEIGER’s 1857 proposal that the vocalisation of the designation “Molek” is a similarly pejorative dysphemism, applying the vowels of *bōsheth* to the term *melekh*, “king”. See further below.

Aramaic *taphyā*, “fire-place”, or derived from a Hebrew root *špt*, “to set (on the fire)”, cognate with Ugaritic *tpd*, “to set”¹². However, these theories remain highly uncertain.

More constructive is the debate concerning the activities the biblical writers allege to have taken place at the tophet. The language most frequently used to refer to these activities is suggestive of burning rituals: sons and/or daughters are “(made to) pass over” (*ha’ābîr*) or are “burned” (*šārāph*) in fire¹³. Whilst a minority of scholars has sought to argue this language is indicative of a “harmless” or non-lethal dedication rite (whether to a temple, foreign gods or nations or – more problematically – cultic prostitution)¹⁴, most agree the language employed in these texts indexes burning to destruction: the book of Ezekiel, for example, repeatedly uses the same language of “passing over” and “burning” alongside the terms “slaughter” (*šāḥaṭ*) and “ritual slaughter” (*zābaḥ*) in a cultic context to describe the offering up of children to deities who are said to “eat” them¹⁵.

Complementing these examples are the longer, less polemically charged narratives in Gen. 22:1-19 and Judg. 11:29-40, in which Abraham and Jephthah each agrees to offer up his beloved child to Yahweh as an *‘ōlāh* – a whole burnt offering (cf. 2 Kgs 3:27)¹⁶. Set within this wider biblical tableau, the tophet is best understood as a ritual site at which the bodies of sons and/or daughters are incinerated. Moreover, the language and contexts of these texts strongly suggest that the biblical writers intend this incineration to be understood as sacrifice, rather than only the disposal of corpses.

Indeed, although ritual sites can perform a variety of functions, the suggestion that the biblical tophet might be best understood more broadly as a site at which corpses were cremated should be treated with caution. Whilst archaeological excavations attest to a relative diversity of mortuary practices in ancient Judah in the Iron II period (including cist graves, shaft tombs, bench tombs and cremation burials)¹⁷, within the *biblical portrayal* of the religious past, a distinctive interment ideology permeates the texts, reflecting complex ideas about the social functions of the ways in which the living dealt with the dead¹⁸. As such, interment in the family tomb, alongside the bones of the ancestors, is frequently idealised and promoted in the Hebrew Bible¹⁹, and this ideology dovetails with a broader and deeply-rooted cultural concern to perpetuate and venerate the post-mortem existence of the dead (cf. 1 Sam. 28:3-25; 2 Sam. 18:18)²⁰.

By contrast, cremation and corpse exposure are negatively associated with the abuse or aggressive disinterment of corpses (for example, 2 Kgs 23:15-20; Jer. 8:1-2), actions

¹² For an overview of these discussions of the term’s etymology and meaning, see HEIDER 1985: 346-50; DAY 1989: 24-28.

¹³ Deut. 12:31; 2 Kgs 17:31; Jer. 7:31; 19:5 (“burn”); 2 Kgs 23:10; Jer. 32:35; Lev. 18:21; Deut. 18:10; 2 Kgs 16:3; 17:17; 21:6; Ezek. 16:21; 20:26, 31; 23:37; 2 Chr. 28:3; 33:6 (“cause to pass over”).

¹⁴ These readings are often encouraged by the interpretations found in the Talmud and other early Jewish writings. See further WILKE 1929; SNAITH 1966; WEINFELD 1972, 1978; BARRICK 2002; cf. HIEKE 2011. On the problematic nature of theories about cultic prostitution, see BUDIN 2008.

¹⁵ Ezek. 16:20, 21; 20:26, 31; 23:37, 39. See also Isa. 57:5; Ps. 106:37-38.

¹⁶ On all these texts, see particularly STAVRAKOPOULOU 2004.

¹⁷ The classic study remains that of BLOCH-SMITH 1992; cf. BLOCH-SMITH 2009.

¹⁸ See further OLYAN 2005; STAVRAKOPOULOU 2010a.

¹⁹ E.g., Judg. 8:32; 16:31; 2 Sam. 2:32; 21:12-14.

²⁰ On post-mortem existence, see LEWIS 2002; NIEHR 2003.

that pose a dangerous threat to both the dead and their living descendants²¹. Within this context, the cremation, mulching or scavenging of corpses is frequently presented as a dangerous process of material and social annihilation: without substantial remains (whether as a fresh fleshy corpse or a collection of skeletal parts), the deceased will cease to exist (2 Kgs 9:34-37)²². This explicit equation of the exposure and destruction of the corpse with the annihilation of the social existence of the dead is well attested in biblical threats of divine punishment (2 Sam. 21:10-14; Jer. 8:1-2; Isa. 14:12-21). Set within the ideological parameters of the biblical frame, the cremation of corpses as opposed to the sacrificial burning of slaughtered humans or animals is thus best understood as a powerful act of dangerous destruction²³. A meaningful illustration of this ideological perspective occurs in the story of Josiah's religious purge in 2 Kings 23, in which the temple of Bethel – the great rival to that in Jerusalem – is disempowered and deprived of its prestigious ancestral pedigree and protection when the bones of the local dead are disinterred from the tombs encircling the sanctuary, and burned to oblivion (2 Kgs 23:15-18; cf. Gen. 35:1-20)²⁴.

In attempting to reconstruct the socio-religious beliefs and practices of ancient societies, a distinction between the ritual burning of human remains for mortuary purposes and the burning of humans or their remains as a sacrifice is often too difficult to discern with any certainty – partly because there is so much about the nature and function of sacrifice and sacrificial offerings in these societies that is unknown, but also because the dynamics and performance of death were likely to have been far more fluid in these societies than modern Western assumptions allow. However, in the world created by the biblical writers (which may or may not reflect historical realities), the activities said to have taken place at the tophet appear akin more to sacrifice than to mortuary rituals: the loaded technical language of sacrifice, set alongside the broader ideologies of corpse treatment in the Hebrew Bible, suggests that the burning of sons and/or daughters at the tophet is to be understood not as an aggressive example of corpse abuse, but as a form of sacrifice, performed by and within the Judahite community. Indeed, it is this perceived contrast in the Hebrew Bible between child sacrifice and corpse abuse that is exploited so artfully in the biblical writers' presentation of the tophet, as will be seen presently.

A feature of the tophet often under-valued in scholarly discussions of its biblical portrayal is its valley location. In keeping with its west Semitic cultural context, the Hebrew Bible exhibits a perception of the cosmos as a three-tiered structure: the earthly realm in which people live is sandwiched between the heavens, located in the sky, and the subterranean realm, which houses the dead. As the "chosen" dwelling place of Yahweh, Jerusalem's sacred topography is schematically mapped onto this cosmology. The mountain-top location of Yahweh's Zion temple therefore manifests the transition between the heavenly and earthly realms, whilst the valleys at the base of the holy mountain function as powerful points of entry into the underworld (cf. Isaiah 14; Ezekiel 28).

²¹ STAVRAKOPOULOU 2010b.

²² *Ibidem*.

²³ Although note that in one particular instance, cremation is employed as a protective means of limiting hostile attacks on the corpses of the dead (1 Sam. 31:8-13).

²⁴ See further STAVRAKOPOULOU 2010a: 81-91.

As sites of transition, the valleys surrounding Jerusalem are thus imbued with a potent mytho-symbolic character; they are liminal locations marking at once three interrelated places: the transitional place between the ordered city and the uncultivated wilderness, the roots of the holy hill upon which the heavenly and earthly realms meet, and the intersection of the earthly realm and the underworld²⁵. Accordingly, all three are associated with the netherworld and/or the realm of the dead: the Kidron valley is a place of cemeteries (2 Kgs 23:6; Jer. 31:40)²⁶; the valley of the Rephaim shares its name with the mythical divinised dead (Gen. 14:5; Deut. 3:11; Josh. 12:4; cf. Isa. 26:14-15)²⁷; and according to the book of Jeremiah, the Ben Hinnom Valley – in which the tophet is said to be located – is destined to be filled with corpses (Jer. 7:32; 19:6)²⁸.

Jerusalem's valleys are therefore also places at which the generations intersect: whether in the form of mortuary and memorial rituals, ancestor veneration or other practices associated with the dead, these valleys are presented as the location at which the living interact with their dead. It is thus unsurprising that child sacrifice might also find a place here. In common with all other attestations of child sacrifice (as opposed to “human” sacrifice) in the Hebrew Bible, the practice is presented in terms of the relationship between the sacrificial offering and its parent, whether it is specifically the “first to open the womb” (Ezek. 20:25-26), the “firstborn” of a parent (1 Kgs 16:34; 2 Kgs 3:26-27), a “beloved” child (Gen. 22:2, 12, 16; Judg. 11:34), or indeed the “son” and/or “daughter” of the offerant himself, as the tophet rituals are consistently described. This not only sets child sacrifice apart from other forms of ritualized human killing (such as the impaling of Saul's sons in 2 Sam. 21:1-9, or Elijah's ritual slaughter of Baal's prophets in 1 Kgs 18:40), it also coheres with strong indications in Hebrew Bible and comparative material that child sacrifice functioned as a specialised life-giving ritual, concerned with a family or household securing, marking or appealing for the fecundity and perpetuation of its future generations – as other rituals expressing the on-going relationship between the living and the dead also appear to have functioned²⁹. Thus it is not unreasonable to suggest that the tophet in the Valley of Ben Hinnom likely represents in its biblical setting a place at which socio-religious generations past, present and future are brought together and exhibited in ritual form³⁰. In this way, it would appear to have something in common with other death and mortuary practices attested within and beyond the Hebrew Bible, in which the familial nexus of relationships across the generations of a particular household, is displayed or “performed” in a more “public” setting³¹.

However, the social context and implications of both the tophet's role and valley location in biblical traditions is all too often overlooked. Instead, the valley's liminal and netherworldly associations are often mistakenly assumed to infer the tophet's infernal, illicit, or “substandard” socio-religious value. This assumption is fed by three

²⁵ On these broad themes in mythic constructions of place, see SMITH 2001: 27-32.

²⁶ On the cemeteries encircling Jerusalem, see RAHMANI 1981a, 1981b, 1981c; USSISHKIN 1993.

²⁷ See further ROUILLARD 1999.

²⁸ On this, see further below.

²⁹ See further STAVRAKOPOULOU 2004, 2010a; cf. LEWIS 2002; OLYAN 2008; MEYERS 2010.

³⁰ Cf. QUINN 2011: 390.

³¹ See further LANERI 2007.

particular factors. The first is the problematic supposition that the valley locations of the dead were always considered to be dangerously defiled by their corpses – a post-biblical Jewish perception that is countered by a number of biblical texts in which tombs, cemeteries and the dead themselves are not presented in dichotomous opposition to “sacred” space and its rituals³². The second is the aligning of hell in some early Jewish and Christian texts with the valley’s Greek name, Gehenna (derived from its Aramaic designation, Gehinnam)³³. Last, the assumption that the tophet was fixed at an “unholy” site is also encouraged by a prominent medieval tradition claiming Ben Hinnom/Gehenna was an unsavoury location at which rubbish and the cadavers of animals and criminals were incinerated³⁴ – a view itself likely derived in part from the claim in 2 Kgs 23:4-6, 11-12 that Josiah removed the cult objects of “foreign” deities from the Jerusalem temple and burned them in the Kidron valley.

Contrary to common opinion, however, the destructive burning of cult objects in the valley is not akin to the incineration of rubbish on the outskirts of a city. It is rather a ritual effecting their transformation – in this case, their “decommissioning” as sacred temple (“heavenly”) vessels and their destructive transference across a mythic boundary from one realm to another, thereby effecting their displacement and rendering their material efficacy redundant³⁵. Jerusalem’s valleys are thus not to be taken for garbage dumps, but rather as liminal spaces of transformative and religio-mythic power. The tophet’s location in the Valley of Ben Hinnom does not index “ungodly” destruction, but instead ritual and cosmic transformation – a location as appropriate for certain forms of sacrifice as the temple on Mount Zion. Indeed, its function as sacred space within the cult of Yahweh is well attested in biblical traditions concerning the tophet, as shall be seen.

2. Recasting the God of the Tophet

Whilst most scholars agree the biblical texts present child sacrifice as the central ritual activity of the tophet, the identity of the divine recipient of these offerings is disputed. Traditionally, the deity in question is held to be Molek. This term, vocalised in the Masoretic text as *mōlekh*, occurs only eight times in the Hebrew Bible: as a cluster of attestations in Leviticus (Lev. 18:21; 20:2, 3, 4, 5), and somewhat more sporadically in 1 Kgs 11:7; 2 Kgs 23:10 and Jer. 32:35³⁶. The term is almost consistently employed in conjunction with the technical terminology of sacrifice in texts depicting children as ritual offerings. Notably, however, the word occurs in relation to the tophet or the Ben Hinnom valley in only two of these texts: 2 Kgs 23:10 and Jer. 32:35, respectively. According to the latter, participation in the Molek cult signals infidelity to Yahweh:

³² STAVRAKOPOULOU 2010a.

³³ WYATT 2009.

³⁴ DAY 1989.

³⁵ STAVRAKOPOULOU 2010a.

³⁶ The occurrence of the term in 1 Kgs 11:7 is highly questionable: the text refers to “Molek of the Ammonites”, but it is almost universally agreed that this divine name should be emended to “Milkom”, the national god of Ammon, who is described in the same way just two verses earlier (11:5).

“They built the high places of Baal in the valley of Ben Hinnom, to make their sons and daughters pass over to Molek, though I did not command them, nor did it enter my mind that they should do this abomination, causing Judah to sin.” (Jer. 32:35).

Given the vociferous condemnation of Molek in all these biblical texts (and perhaps spurred on by the mutually-derogatory association of Baal and Molek in the verse cited above)³⁷, scholars have long argued that *mōlekh* is the name or epithet of a “foreign” deity, a deity depicted as wholly at odds with the worship of Yahweh, and venerated only by idolatrous, rebellious Israelites³⁸.

However, the scarcity of biblical attestations of *mōlekh*, combined with the seeming absence of non-biblical evidence for the worship of a deity of this name (let alone a deity particularly associated with child sacrifice, as will be discussed below) renders uncertain the traditional assumption that biblical *mōlekh* is the name of a foreign god. Instead, there remains much to commend Otto Eissfeldt’s now familiar proposal that biblical *mōlekh* was originally a technical term for a type of sacrifice, cognate with Phoenician-Punic *mlk* employed in formulaic dedicatory inscriptions on monuments erected over the burnt and buried remains of babies, infants and young animals at a range of Phoenician-Punic sites³⁹. Whereas earlier interpreters had understood the *mlk* component of these inscriptions simply as the name or title of a deity, accompanying sacrificial terms in these inscriptions, such as the Phoenician-Punic verbs *ytn* (“give”), *zbh* (“sacrifice”) and *nš*’ (“present”, “offer”) seem to confirm Eissfeldt’s understanding of Phoenician-Punic *mlk* as a type of sacrifice⁴⁰. Accordingly, Eissfeldt’s proposal that the Hebrew Bible refers not to a deity Molek or Melek, but to a practice in which children are “passed over in the fire as a *mlk*-sacrifice” has persuaded a number of scholars⁴¹.

Eissfeldt’s theory has been challenged, however, by the resurrection of the traditional view that the Hebrew Bible attests to a foreign deity of child sacrifice. Whilst they broadly accept Eissfeldt’s reading of the Phoenician-Punic inscriptions⁴², George Heider and John Day agree that biblical *mōlekh* reflects a divine name derived from the common (west) Semitic stem *mlk*, “rule” or “be king”⁴³. Significantly, whilst

³⁷ On the deliberate association of Molek and Baal here (and the possibility it is a later insertion), see further STAVRAKOPOULOU 2004; cf. EDELMAN 1987.

³⁸ HEIDER 1985; DAY 1989; SCHMIDT 1994; MILGROM 2002; HAYES 2011.

³⁹ EISSFELDT 1935.

⁴⁰ Advocates of the view that the Phoenician-Punic tophets are infant cemeteries, rather than sacrificial sites, tend to adhere to this older interpretation of the term *m(o)lk*. See most notably BÉNICHOU-SAFAR 1982; MOSCATI 1987; RIBICHINI 1987; MOSCATI – RIBICHINI 1991.

⁴¹ Supporters include MOSCA 1975; MÜLLER 1884; OLYAN 1988; ACKERMAN 1992; SMELIK 1995; SMITH 2002; STAVRAKOPOULOU 2004; REYNOLDS 2007.

⁴² DAY 1989 agrees with EISSFELDT 1935 that Phoenician-Punic *m(o)lk* is a sacrificial term, but follows VON SODEN 1936 in deriving both Phoenician-Punic *m(o)lk* and biblical *mōlekh* from the radicals *hlk*, “go”. See also REYNOLDS 2007.

⁴³ HEIDER 1985 argues the Masoretic form *mōlekh* is a “frozen” participle form, functioning as the epithet “Molek”, meaning “the Reigning One”. By contrast, DAY 1989 follows GEIGER 1957 in arguing the deity’s name was originally “Melek” (“King”, “Ruler”), but was deliberately revocalised with the vowels of the term *bōsheth*, “shame”. For arguments against this view, see MOSCA 1975; TSEVAT 1975; cf. HAMILTON 1998.

the names and epithets of a number of ancient deities probably exhibit a derivation from this stem, both Heider and Day argue independently that “Molek” was specifically a Canaanite god, a deity whom they propose is attested in two Ugaritic snake-charm texts which appear to mention a divine being *MLK* dwelling in “Ashtaroth”, a partially mythical location associated with the underworld (KTU 1.100.41; 1.107.42)⁴⁴. Support for this view is garnered with reference to one particular biblical occurrence of *mōlekh*, in a verse condemning the Israelites for “whoring after the *mōlekh*” (Lev. 20:5). As Day and Heider point out, this language of sexual transgression is frequently employed metaphorically in the Hebrew Bible to refer to the religious infidelity of Yahweh-worshippers who venerate other gods or ritual objects⁴⁵.

For Day, the strongest evidence for a Canaanite deity of child sacrifice is one verse in the Hebrew Bible, Isa. 57:9, which associates journeying to the “king” (*melekh*, which Day assumes to be an undistorted example of the deity’s name) with “sending to Sheol”, a biblical phrase referring to descent to the underworld⁴⁶. By contrast, Heider’s primary objection to Eissfeldt’s proposal is what he perceives to be a lack of evidence from the Syro-Phoenician mainland for the incineration of infant remains and their related dedicatory inscriptions. The sacrificial meaning of the dedicatory term *mlk*, he contends, is an “intra-Punic development” unrelated to religious practice on the Syro-Phoenician mainland, and is not to be related to the biblical portrayal of child sacrifice⁴⁷.

However, there are a number of problems with these proposals. The first is that because both Heider and Day accept Eissfeldt’s interpretation of Phoenician-Punic *mlk* as a sacrificial term, their positions are at once compromised by the possibility that biblical *mōlekh* could well function in a similar way as a technical term for a type of sacrifice. Their claim that “whoring after the *mōlekh*” in Lev. 20:5 attests to the worship of a deity or a ritual object, rather than the offering of a sacrifice, is crucial to their position. However, Eissfeldt’s original suggestion (often overlooked or misunderstood by his critics), that *mōlekh* refers both to the act of sacrifice and to the material entity to be sacrificed, offers a powerful alternative explanation⁴⁸. Indeed, this function of sacrificial language is well attested in the Hebrew Bible, with terms such as *zebah* and *’ōlāh* performing in the same way⁴⁹. Thus in Lev. 20:5 the Israelites could well be understood to “whore after the *mlk*-offering”, just as they are accused of “whoring after” the ephod made by Gideon in Judg. 8:27. This is also the way in which supporters of Eissfeldt read Isa. 57:9, so that it is equally plausible that it is the material *mlk*-victim which is associated with Sheol, rather than a deity⁵⁰.

⁴⁴ HEIDER 1985; DAY 1989. Both have summarised their proposals: HEIDER 1992, 1999; DAY 2000.

⁴⁵ E.g., Isa. 57:3; Jer. 2:20; Ezek. 16:1-63; 23:1-49; Hos. 2:5; 4:10-15.

⁴⁶ DAY 1989.

⁴⁷ HEIDER 1985.

⁴⁸ EISSFELDT 1935: 39.

⁴⁹ MOSCA 1975: 155-157.

⁵⁰ ACKERMAN 1992; STAVRAKOPOULOU 2004. The ambiguity of the notoriously corrupt Hebrew of the poem in which this verse appears in its own turn challenges DAY’s 1985 contention that the text has in view a Canaanite deity, rather than a ritual in a series of practices indexing indigenous Judahite rituals. On the problems of the dichotomizing distinction between “Canaanite” religion and “Israelite” or “Judahite” religion, see NIEHR 2010.

This alternative rendering of Isa. 57:9 further weakens Day's particular position, for this verse necessarily has to play a crucial part in his argument for a "foreign" deity of child sacrifice, given that non-biblical evidence for the worship of a distinct west Semitic deity of the underworld named "Mlk" is so difficult to identify. Indeed, this amounts to the second major weakness of the case for a Canaanite god of child sacrifice: the Ugaritic snake-charm texts to which Heider and Day call attention are highly ambiguous, and thus too precarious a foundation upon which to build a case for a distinctly "Canaanite" god of child sacrifice. Some have suggested not that the texts refer to a distinct deity "Mlk" dwelling in Ashtaroth, but to the Ugaritic high-god, El (Ilu)⁵¹, or to some other deity bearing the epithet "*mlk*", "king"⁵²; others have pointed to the Transjordanian location ascribed to Ashtaroth in biblical texts (traditions about which bear numerous traces of an identification with the netherworld)⁵³, and suggested that this location could be related more profitably to Milkom, the god of the Ammonites – a suggestion bolstered by the likelihood that this is the deity with whom biblical "Molek" is confused in 1 Kgs 11:5-7⁵⁴. Moreover, plausible evidence for the association of any deity at Ugarit with child sacrifice or human sacrifice is unknown⁵⁵.

Lastly, Heider's emphasis on the "missing link" between the distinctive incineration practices of the Phoenician-Punic colonies and the Syro-Phoenician mainland – as well as territories associated with the nearby states of Israel and Judah – demands careful handling and contextualization. Archaeological evidence for the burning, interring and marking of human remains beneath inscribed monuments – some of which exhibit iconographical symbols attested at the Carthaginian tophet – is attested at Phoenician mainland sites, including Tyre itself and Akhziv, a coastal site nine miles north of Akko⁵⁶. However, although a number of scholars argue these sites should be considered "tophets" (whether or not adults or infants were burned at these locations)⁵⁷, it is uncertain as to whether their material remains have any serious bearing on the debates surrounding tophets. Scholarship of recent years has also given rise to a more nuanced understanding of the diversities of both "Phoenician" socio-cultural identities and the "tophets" associated with them⁵⁸. This not only cautions against assuming an overarching (and colonially-derived) cultural milieu shared by various towns and cities identified as "Phoenician", but also in some ways renders redundant Heider's objection that "Phoenician" settlements on the eastern Mediterranean coast should exhibit evidence of practices notably similar to those known from Carthage's tophet.

Nonetheless, it remains noteworthy that certain ancient sites in the Levant, including some in modern day Lebanon, Israel and Palestine, attest to a constellation of practices

⁵¹ LEVINE – TARRAGON 1984; cf. FERRARA – PARKER 1972.

⁵² OLYAN – SMITH 1987.

⁵³ See STAVRAKOPOULOU 2010: 68-70 and the literature cited there.

⁵⁴ DEL OLMO LETE 1990; WYATT 1998: 383; ASTOUR 1968; cf. TREBOLLE BARRERA 1987.

⁵⁵ Cf. SMITH 2002; contra SPALINGER 1978 (cf. DERCHAIN 1970); LANGE 2007.

⁵⁶ SEEDEN 1991, 1992; COHEENEY – PIPE 1991; SADER 1991, 1992; PRAUSNITZ – MAZAR 1993; WOLFF 1994. For other sites possibly attesting to the burning and interring of human remains in territories associated with – or in reasonable proximity to – Phoenician mainland towns, see STAVRAKOPOULOU 2004: 224-226, and the literature cited there.

⁵⁷ Notably SADER 1991, 1992; SEEDEN 1991, 1992; WOLFF 1994.

⁵⁸ BONNET 2011; QUINN 2011.

sufficiently consistent with those evidenced at locations in North Africa and around the Mediterranean as to answer Heider's principal objection, namely the apparent absence of evidence for exhibited ritual incineration in regions closer to ancient Israel and Judah⁵⁹. This case against Heider is further supported by two important Phoenician stele inscriptions, both of which attest to the strong possibility that *mlk* was known and employed as a sacrificial term in mainland Phoenicia. One is held to date to the eighth century BCE and was found at Incirli in southern Turkey. Although badly worn and damaged, it appears to refer to the *mlk*-sacrifice of a number of animals⁶⁰. The other is a fragmentary votive inscription from the coastal site of Nebi Yunis, near Ashdod, dated to the third or second century BCE, and may similarly attest to the use of Phoenician *mlk* as a sacrificial term on the mainland⁶¹.

On balance, then, the similarity of Phoenician-Punic *mlk* and the biblical term *mōlekh*, combined with their shared context of the ritual incineration of children is, as Klaas Smelik comments, "too striking to be thought merely coincidental"⁶². Indeed, an increasing number of scholars now take the biblical traditions to attest not to the offering of children in fiery sacrifices to the deity "Molek", but rather to the sacrifice of children as "*mlk*" offerings to another deity⁶³. As such, the persuasiveness of the case for a distinctly "Canaanite" god of the Jerusalem tophet is increasingly perceived to have fallen flat – leaving in its place a cult site more closely associated with Yahweh than any other deity, as further scrutiny of the biblical traditions suggests.

3. Re-sanctifying the Tophet

Despite numerous attempts to present an ideologically coherent and ostensibly monotheistic portrayal of their religious past, the biblical writers' discomfort with the polytheisms of ancient Israel and Judah is evident in their scathing, retrospective attacks upon what modern historians increasingly consider to have been the indigenous, traditional and normative religious practices of these ancient societies⁶⁴. And in common with many ancient cultures – and indeed some modern-day societies – the sacrifice or "ritual killing" of humans, whether infant or adult, was in certain contexts both accepted and sanctioned. Although it is presented in various ways – including its manifestation as a tophet ritual – child sacrifice is thus a relatively well-attested cultic activity in the Hebrew Bible⁶⁵.

Significantly, however, it is also presented as a prestigious sacrifice of high religious value: both Abraham and Jephthah seek to offer up their "beloved" and "only-begotten"

⁵⁹ A case-study attesting to "travelling" of cremation rituals from one culture to another is discussed by RUTHERFORD 2007.

⁶⁰ KAUFMAN 2007.

⁶¹ GIANTO 1987; cf. HEIDER 1985; SMITH 2002.

⁶² SMELIK 1995: 138.

⁶³ See the publications listed in n. 41, above.

⁶⁴ See further STAVRAKOPOULOU – BARTON 2010.

⁶⁵ Gen. 22:1-19; Lev. 18:21; 20:2-5; Deut. 12:31; 18:10; Josh. 6:26; Judg. 11:30-40; 1 Kgs 16:34; 2 Kgs 3:27; 16:3; 17:17, 31; 21:6; 23:10; 2 Chr. 28:3; 33:6; Ps. 106:37-38; Isa. 57:5; Jer. 7:31; 19:5; 32:35; Ezek. 16:20-21; 20:26, 31; 23:37, 39; Mic. 6:7.

children to their god (Gen. 22:2, 12, 16; Judg. 11:34)⁶⁶; Micah depicts the offering of the “fruit of the womb” as the most valuable of sacrifices to Yahweh (Mic. 6:6-7); and even Yahweh himself insists that the firstborn be offered up to him – in some texts, without redemption or substitution – as a defining feature of the cult of the covenant (Exod. 13:1-2; 22:28-29; cf. 13:13; 34:20)⁶⁷. Indeed, it is the high socio-religious value of the sacrificed child that characterises its inherent association with both the god of the Hebrew Bible and the great founding father of the Israelite people: Abraham receives a divine blessing precisely for his willingness to sacrifice his son to Yahweh (Gen. 22:16-18).

Contrary to some contemporary scholars’ heavily-freighted assertions that child sacrifice is presented in the Hebrew Bible as a “pagan” practice of the “barbarian Other”⁶⁸, that is “shameful”⁶⁹, “dangerous”⁷⁰, and even “dark, foreign, occult [and] ... demonic”⁷¹, the biblical writers themselves pass no explicitly “ethical” judgement on the practice⁷². Rather, in a number of texts, Yahweh is unambiguously portrayed as a willing recipient of child sacrifice.

It is against this broader backdrop that biblical traditions about the tophet must be set – and which might go some way to explaining why, in the book of Jeremiah, Yahweh appears keen to counter a perception that he demanded his worshippers offer up their children. In all three texts associated with the tophet cult in this book, Yahweh repeatedly and emphatically asserts that neither did he command the burning of children nor did it even enter his mind (Jer. 7:31; 19:5; 32:35). As Jon Levenson comments, this three-fold denial might suggest “the prophet doth protest too much”⁷³, particularly in view of the close ritual interlinking of Yahweh’s temple with the tophet cult in Jer. 7:30-31, which is complemented by the similar association of the *mlk*-practice with Yahweh’s cult in the book of Leviticus, in which the sacrifice of offspring is said to “defile” Yahweh’s sanctuary (Lev. 20:3) and “profane” the divine name (Lev. 18:21; 20:3).

The close association of Yahweh-worship with child sacrifice is similarly articulated in the book of Ezekiel. Here, the practice is immediately followed by rituals in Yahweh’s temple (Ezek. 23:38-39) while Yahweh personifies his worshippers as his errant wives, who sacrifice to their other divine lovers the children upon whom, it would appear, he has rightful claim (Ezek. 16:20-21; 23:37-39). Thus:

⁶⁶ On this language, and its parallels in the Phoenician myth about El’s sacrifice of his son in Philo of Byblos’ *Phoenician History* (Euseb. *Praep. ev.* 1.10.33, 44; GIFFORD 1903), see STAVRAKOPOULOU 2004: 290-92; cf. LEVENSON 1993: 26-31; BAUKS 2007.

⁶⁷ On the firstborn sacrifice, see further VAN SETERS 1998; STAVRAKOPOULOU 2004; FINSTERBUSCH 2007.

⁶⁸ NOORT 2007: 119.

⁶⁹ KING 1993: 139.

⁷⁰ HAYES 2011: 183.

⁷¹ COOK 2009: 109-10. On some of the problems of this sort of language in scholarship, see STAVRAKOPOULOU 2010c: 44-47.

⁷² *Contra* NOORT 2007; cf. HORST 1992; BOEHM 2004.

⁷³ LEVENSON 1993: 4; cf. GREEN 1975: 178.

“... they have committed adultery, they have even passed over to them for food their sons whom they had borne to me. Moreover, they have defiled my sanctuary on the same day, and polluted my sabbaths, for when they had ritually slaughtered their children for their shit-gods, on the same day they came into my sanctuary to profane it. This is what they did in my temple.” (Ezek. 23:37-39).

Perhaps most striking, however, is Yahweh’s frank admission, couched in the language of the covenant regulations⁷⁴, that he did indeed legislate for child sacrifice – and the related implication that his worshippers performed this ritual accordingly:

“... I gave them no-good decrees and laws by which they could not live. I defiled them through their gifts, in their passing over every first-birth of the womb, in order that I might devastate them, so that they might know I am Yahweh.” (Ezek. 20:25-26).

Although neither the term *mōlekh* nor the tophet makes an explicit appearance in the book of Ezekiel, collectively, these texts reflect a perception that Yahweh-worshippers believed their god had commanded child sacrifice. It is portrayed either as an acknowledged part of the cult of Yahweh (20:25-26), or in conjunction with it (worship in Yahweh’s temple accompanies the ritual slaughter of children in 23:39), or as a ritual alongside it (in 16:20-21, the children sacrificed are those fathered by Yahweh).

The relationship between Yahweh and the tophet is nowhere more explicitly and graphically articulated than in Isa. 30:27-33, a prophetic poem describing Yahweh’s impending destruction of the imperial overlord, Assyria, personified here as a sacrificial offering. The tophet is imaged as a fixed installation⁷⁵, specially enlarged to house the gigantic body of Assyria:

“For tophet (*tophteh*) is long-prepared;
he himself is prepared for the king/the *mlk*-sacrifice⁷⁶,
(Yahweh) has made his firepit deep and wide,
with fire and wood in abundance.
The breath of Yahweh,
like a torrent of sulphur,
sets it ablaze.” (Isa. 30:33).

Whether the occurrence of *melekh* (“king”) in this verse is taken to refer to the Assyrian monarch or to the sacrificial practice associated with Jerusalem’s tophet⁷⁷, it nonetheless presents Yahweh as the divine recipient of the fiery offering. The sacrifice is depicted as the evening climax to a ritual procession to Yahweh’s mountain (likely a

⁷⁴ PATTON 1996; VAN SETERS 1998; cf. HORST 1992.

⁷⁵ Cf. ZEVIT 2001.

⁷⁶ For those defending the existence of a god “Molek”, Masoretic *melekh* here can be revocalized *mōlekh*; for those adhering to the theory that the vowels of *bōsheth* have been applied to an original *melekh*, it can be left unaltered in its apparent preservation of the deity’s name (“King”), whilst supporters of EISSFELDT’s 1935 proposal prefer to see here a reference to the “*mlk*-victim”. Interestingly, HEIDER 1985 chooses not to emend, for he reads *melekh* here as a straightforward reference to the Assyrian king who is to be destroyed by Yahweh, not as a reference to “Molek”.

⁷⁷ See note above.

reference to Zion)⁷⁸, with singing, music and dancing (Isa. 30:29, 32). Recalling Ezek. 16:20-21 and 23:37, which refer to the recipient deity eating sacrificed children, an intense sensory focus upon Yahweh's lips, tongue and breath, set in direct relation to a consuming fire, alludes to his imminent devouring of the sacrifice:

“Look! The name of Yahweh comes from far away,
blazing his anger,
ominous his pronouncement⁷⁹;
his lips full of anger,
his tongue like a devouring fire;
his breath like an overflowing torrent
that reaches up to the neck ...”. (Isa. 30:27-28).

Yet perhaps the most arresting feature of this poem is its portrayal of Yahweh as the divine sacrificer, for it is Yahweh – described a few verses later as the god whose “fire is in Zion, and whose furnace is in Jerusalem” (Isa. 31:9) – who is depicted as preparing and setting alight the sacrificial firepit, having defeated the personified Assyria (Isa. 30:31-33). The imaging of Assyria as the sacrificial victim of Yahweh's tophet creates a powerful polemic against the colonial and military might of Judah's imperial overlord, here presented as a ritual offering destined for spectacular sacrifice.

This explicit portrayal of Yahweh at the tophet, both offering up and devouring a sacrifice, is striking – and clearly unsettling for some scholars. George Heider, for example, comments, “... one can hardly imagine Isaiah approving of the cult, but his words were intended to communicate, using known imagery”⁸⁰. Similarly, Ziony Zevit asserts that the poet's “language is metaphoric”, even though “the cultic appartenance he describes was real”⁸¹. By apparent contrast, Christopher Hays acknowledges that the author of this text “clearly approves” of Yahweh's actions against the personified Assyria, and yet distances the deity from the discomfiting implications of what he calls the sacrifice of “presumably innocent” children by insisting the text simply describes the abusive cremation of Assyria's corpse⁸².

However, whilst corpse abuse is indeed a common feature of biblical traditions in which the imperial rhetoric of violence is turned against Judah's colonial aggressors⁸³, and is glimpsed in this poem as Yahweh restrains and pummels his military enemy (Isa. 30:28, 31-32), the sacrificial connotations of the tophet employed in Isa. 30:27-33 transform this abuse into a distinctly more “sacred” act of ritual dedication. This is supported by an intriguing parallel in Ezekiel 38–39⁸⁴. In these chapters, the annihilation of Gog and his army, the mythological, personified enemy from the north, similarly draws on motifs associated with the tophet to depict the fallen enemy explicitly as Yahweh's sacrificial victim. Although Gog's body is not burned, but rather

⁷⁸ E.g., Isa. 2:2-3; 11:9; 25:6-10; Ezek. 28:24; Ps. 48:1-3; 78:54.

⁷⁹ Following MOSCA 1975: 201, 203.

⁸⁰ HEIDER 1999: 584.

⁸¹ ZEVIT 2001: 522.

⁸² HAYES 2011: 227.

⁸³ E.g., Isa. 14:12-21; Ezek. 29:5; 32:4, 5-6. For the abuse of corpses in Mesopotamian political rhetoric, see RICHARDSON 2007.

⁸⁴ See further STAVRAKOPOULOU 2010b.

buried, exhumed and scavenged, these chapters share with Isa. 30:27-33 a number of features⁸⁵.

Whilst these include distinctive but shared vocabulary and imagery, of particular significance is the complex wordplay employed in the description of Gog's burial place. In Ezek. 39:11, the site is given two names: one is the "Valley of Hamon-Gog" ("Valley of the Horde of Gog"), which scholars agree plays on the name of the location of the tophet, the Ben Hinnom valley, outside Jerusalem⁸⁶, and which is itself described in this text as Hamonah, a symbolic name of the city⁸⁷. As described above, set within the mytho-symbolic landscape reflected in biblical traditions, the valleys encircling Jerusalem are constructed in relation to the heavenly heights of Yahweh's dwelling place, Mount Zion, so that they function as entrances to the netherworld, across which the dead "pass over" or "cross over" (cf. Job 33:18)⁸⁸. This function is indexed by the other name ascribed to Gog's valley in Ezek. 39:11 (cf. 39:15), the "Valley of Oberim" ("Valley of those Passing Over"), a designation also alluding to the technical language of the tophet ritual, in which children are "made to pass over" in fire.

Yet perhaps the most striking aspect of this text is that in the ritualised imaging of the destruction of Gog and his army – as in the Isaiah passage discussed above – Yahweh is presented as the divine sacrificer: it is Yahweh who prepares the seemingly exhumed enemy corpses as a sacrificial feast fit for consumption at his table:

"... thus says Lord Yahweh: Speak to the birds of every kind and come to all the wild animals: Assemble and come, gather from all around to the sacrificial feast I am preparing for you, a great sacrificial feast on the mountains of Israel, and you shall eat flesh and drink blood ..." (Ezek. 39:17; cf. vv. 19-20)⁸⁹.

Thus in both Isa. 30:27-33 and Ezek. 39:11-20, the divine abuse of corpses is sanctified in its re-imaging as a sacrifice, located either at the tophet (Isa. 30:27-33) or in the valley of Ben Hinnom and the holy heights towering over it (Ezek. 39:11-20).

That this is a powerful trope, rather than a striking coincidence, is further suggested by the sharp parallels between the narrative dealing with Yahweh's destruction of Gog's army in Ezekiel 39:11-20, and those concerning the tophet in Jeremiah 7 and 19. In both these texts, Yahweh targets the tophet as a site at which he will exhibit his punishment of his wayward people. Just as the buried corpses of Gog and his horde will create a mound so large they will block the valley identified with Ben Hinnom (Ezek. 39:11), so too in Jer. 7:30-33 and 19:6-11, corpses are to be buried at the site of the tophet in Ben Hinnom in such number that they will ultimately fill the valley (7:32; 19:11), which will be renamed (7:32; 19:6) – much as the burial of Gog's army prompts the valley's renaming (Ezek. 39:11). And just as the corpses filling the valley in Ezek. 39:17-20 are to be scavenged and devoured, so too the corpses in the book of Jeremiah:

⁸⁵ IRWIN 1995. Though Irwin supports the view that "Molek" is to be regarded as a god of child sacrifice, distinct from YHWH, many of his observations remain instructive.

⁸⁶ ZIMMERLI 1983; BLENKINSOPP 1990.

⁸⁷ ODELL 1994.

⁸⁸ MONTGOMERY 1908; POPE 1977; RIBICHINI – XELLA 1980; BAILEY 1986; WYATT 2009.

⁸⁹ Cf. Isa. 34:6-8; Zeph. 1:7.

“... the days are coming – oracle of Yahweh – when it will no longer be called the tophet, or the Valley of Ben Hinnom, but the Valley of Slaughter, for they will bury in the tophet until there is no more room. And the corpses of this people will be food for the birds of the air and for the animals of the earth ...” (Jer. 7:32-33; cf. 19:6-11).

However, whilst in Isa. 30:27-33 and Ezek. 39:11-20, divine corpse abuse is re-imagined as sacrifice, in Jer. 7:32-33 and 19:6-11, this motif is inverted, for the place of sacrifice is to be transformed into a site of corpse abuse. This inversion of the tophet’s function as a place of sacrifice to a burial site perhaps gives some indication of a perceived function of the sacrifices, for the tophet’s transformed role in these narratives occurs within the context of social disorder, in which rituals associated with the perpetuation of the generations will come to an end: the living will be unable to care for their dead (7:33; 19:7-8), but will be forced to eat them into oblivion instead (19:9); the ancestors will be disinterred from their place in the underworld and left to rot away (8:1-2); the joining of a bride and groom – and by implication, the birth of new life – will come to an end (7:34), and the cultivated land itself will become a barren wasteland (7:34).

Thus the cessation of activities at the tophet, and the transformation of its valley into a place of slaughter instead of sacrifice, similarly underscores the suggestion that it was perceived by worshippers to have been the site of life-giving rituals. Indeed, this complements the portrayal of child sacrifice elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible, in which it is presented as a specialised life-giving ritual, bringing blessings of perpetual fertility (for example, Gen. 22:1-19)⁹⁰.

These oracles in Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel present both the Ben Hinnom valley and its tophet as a suitable location at which to stage a divine drama of cosmic proportions – be it the defeat of an imperial enemy of mythic proportions (Assyria and Gog) or indeed the rendering of Yahweh’s Jerusalem as a dystopia (as in Jer. 7:30-8:3; 19:6-13). This in its turn suggests that, despite the critique directed at the practices of the tophet in some texts, the perception remained that it was an appropriately and powerfully sacred place at which the transformation of reality might be indexed – as indeed its function as a sacrificial cult place of a notably high status would also indicate, for this is a place at which the elites of Yahweh’s cult gather and perform, including his royal servants, the kings of Judah (Jer. 19:3, 13; cf. 2 Kgs 16:3; 21:6); his senior priests and elders (Jer. 19:1); his cultic musicians and singers (Isa. 30:27-33); his prophet (Jer. 19:2, 14), and even the deity himself (Isa. 30:33).

The explicit association of high status personnel with the tophet in these texts, coupled with the dynamic interplay between the inverted motifs of divine corpse abuse and divine sacrifice, points to the adoption and adaption of the tophet as an ideological index in the biblical traditions: sacrifice at the tophet is displaced from its exhibited familial social location, in which a father offers up his child in full view of the dead in Jerusalem’s valleys, and set instead on the national and cosmic stage; it is artfully transformed from a human activity into a divine performance, a performance bound up with the manifestation and perpetuation not of a specific household, but of Yahweh’s chosen nation in its wordly context, as the deity defeats his “foreign” enemies.

⁹⁰ STAVRAKOPOULOU 2004.

4. Remembering the Tophet

Within biblical scholarship, the tophet tends to be “remembered” as a site of long-lost religious and social abhorrence. It is a place at which unfaithful, idolatrous Yahweh-worshippers sacrificed their children in honour of an ancient Canaanite deity called Molek – a deity distinct from the god of the Bible. And yet this clumsy caricature is somewhat at odds with the biblical presentation, which is far more ambivalent in its presentation of the tophet than most scholars contend.

Indeed, a notable tension underscores biblical texts dealing with the tophet and its associated rituals. In most, the sacrifice of children is condemned as a cult crime marking “otherness”: it is presented as an idolatrous practice, a ritual devoted to a “foreign” god, rather than Yahweh. Religious infidelity, rather than social deviancy, thus seems to be the force of the biblical writers’ complaints about the “burning” or “passing over” of children in the fire. And yet this jars with significant indications in the texts themselves that Yahweh was believed to be closely associated with the tophet and its practices – as indeed he is with other forms of child sacrifice in the Hebrew Bible.

This pervasive association undermines the conventional reading of biblical *mōlekh* as a divine name, and foregrounds instead the notable similarity of Phoenician-Punic *mlk* and *mōlekh* which, coupled with their shared context of the ritual burning of children, renders unpersuasive the biblical case for “Molek” as an independent god of child sacrifice. Rather, it is more likely that the biblical term *mōlekh* functioned as a technical term for a type of sacrifice, much as it appears to have done in its Phoenician-Punic settings. Whether this term came to be unintentionally misunderstood or misrepresented by the tradents of the biblical traditions, or was deliberately distorted by later scribes into the name of an invented deity⁹¹, remains uncertain. But the emergence of Molek as a fictitious biblical character has come to play a key role in the theological and ideological distancing of the god of the Bible from a practice that was once associated with Yahweh-worship in ancient Judah.

The success of this distancing strategy is well attested in modern biblical scholarship, in which the unsettling presence of child sacrifice in the Hebrew Bible is often blamed on the influence of long-dead “foreign” religious cultures. But it is a distancing strategy weakened by numerous traces in the biblical texts of Yahweh’s legitimate place at the tophet, and its prestigious and powerful function as a sacred place.

Indeed, the inherent sanctity of the tophet is attested even in those texts seeking most aggressively to discredit it as a cult site. In 2 Kgs 23:10, the text with which this discussion began, the tophet is subjected to Josiah’s religious purge, for it is explicitly said to have been desacralized (“defiled” or “polluted”) as a sacrificial site⁹². So too in Jer. 7:31-8:2 and 19:6-15 (cf. 32:26-35), the tophet in its valley location is transformed into a place of burial, rather than sacrifice. In these texts the cessation of activities at the

⁹¹ So SMELIK 1995.

⁹² Although the biblical writer does not suggest the way in which this might have been thought to occur – an anomalous omission in the context of what is otherwise a detailed portrayal of cultic decommissioning – it is the related description of corpse disinterment in Jerusalem and bone burning at Bethel in 23:14, 15-20 has led some scholars to argue the tophet is to be similarly understood to have been rendered a place for “ordinary” human corpses, rather than sacrifice, as might also be suggested in the oracles concerning the tophet and the valley of Ben Hinnom in Jer. 7:31-8:2; 19:6-15 (cf. 32:26-35).

tophet is presented as a divine punishment, although – somewhat tellingly – it is uncertain as to whether this is to be understood as a divine judgement on the tophet itself, or simply as an effective means of Yahweh attacking the life-giving rituals of his people (cf. Ezek. 20:25-26). Regardless, the enduring sanctity of the tophet and its valley location, and a pervasive association with Yahweh, is not only “remembered” but powerfully reasserted in one of the most striking oracles of the book of Jeremiah:

“The whole valley of the dead bodies and the ashes, and all the terraces⁹³ as far as the Wadi Kidron, to the corner of the Horse Gate towards the east, shall be sacred to Yahweh. It shall never again be uprooted or overthrown.” (Jer. 31:40).

In this remarkable text, the network of valleys encircling Jerusalem is caught part-way between ideology and religious transformation: what is defamed in earlier chapters of Jeremiah as a sacrificial site clogged with corpses is instead celebrated here as a religious site of the highest status. Set alongside the burial grounds of the ancestral dead, the place of ashes, the liminal burning place in the Valley of Ben Hinnom, is once again claimed to be persistently and permanently sacred to Yahweh – the god of the tophet.

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⁹³ Reading *šdmwt*, “terraces”, for Masoretic *šrmwt*. See further WYATT 1992.

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